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ARTICLE

When Every Device Becomes A Tracking Device





BY PNW STAFF JULY 08, 2026

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There was a time when leaving home meant leaving a trail only if someone happened to see you. Today, without ever touching your phone, sending a text, or making a call, you may already be broadcasting your location to dozens of nearby sensors.

And now, a new surveillance technology promises to stitch all those electronic breadcrumbs together.

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It is called SignalTrace, and while its name may be unfamiliar today, the technology behind it offers a revealing glimpse into where modern surveillance is heading. Developed by global defense and security giant Leonardo, SignalTrace is designed to help law enforcement identify not merely vehicles, but the people traveling inside them.

Rather than relying solely on license plates, it correlates the unique wireless signals emitted by smartphones, Bluetooth devices, vehicle systems, RFID tags, tire-pressure monitoring sensors, and other electronic devices to create what the company describes as an "electronic fingerprint."

Unlike Hollywood hacking scenes, the system is not reading your text messages or listening to your phone calls. Instead, it collects the identifiers constantly emitted by many of the wireless devices we carry every day. Individually, those signals reveal very little. But together they create a remarkably distinctive signature—one that can potentially be associated with a specific vehicle, tracked over time, and recognized again and again.

In many ways, SignalTrace represents the next evolution of automated license plate readers. Those systems were originally introduced to identify stolen vehicles and locate wanted criminals. Few objected. Catching dangerous offenders seemed a reasonable use of technology.

But surveillance technologies rarely remain confined to their original purpose.



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Over the past two decades, governments have quietly assembled an increasingly interconnected web of digital observation. Security cameras became high-definition networks. License plate readers expanded from isolated police departments into nationwide databases. Smartphones evolved into constant sources of location information. Facial recognition became capable of identifying individuals within seconds. Financial transactions, online activity, and digital identities have become increasingly centralized.

Each advancement was introduced independently, usually accompanied by assurances that it would only be used for limited, legitimate purposes.

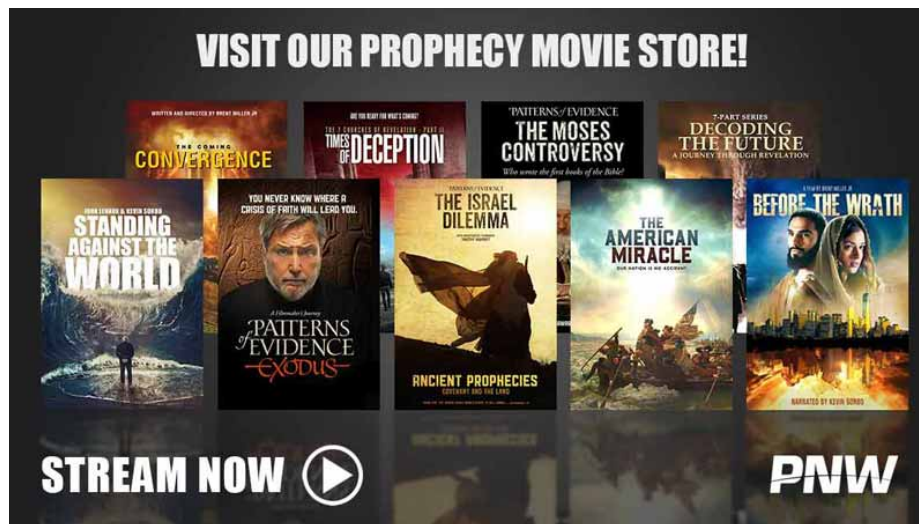
Yet taken together, they paint a very different picture.

SignalTrace is noteworthy not simply because of what it can do today, but because of what it represents. It seeks to bridge the gap between vehicles and occupants, allowing investigators to associate recurring collections of electronic devices with specific people rather than merely tracking a license plate. A car can change owners. A license plate can be replaced. But the combination of your smartphone, smartwatch, wireless earbuds, vehicle electronics, and other nearby devices creates a much more persistent digital signature.

The technology itself is impressive.

The broader implications are sobering.

Artificial intelligence has dramatically accelerated those implications. A decade ago, even if governments collected billions of data points, making sense of them required enormous human effort. Today, AI systems can rapidly analyze vast quantities of information, identify recurring patterns, uncover associations, and reconstruct what security professionals call a "pattern of life."



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Imagine asking a computer:

Who regularly visits this church?

Which vehicles consistently travel together?

Who attended a political rally and then met with certain individuals afterward?

Which electronic fingerprints appeared near a crime scene multiple times over six months?

These are precisely the kinds of questions modern AI excels at answering.

Supporters rightly point out that such capabilities could solve crimes, locate missing persons, dismantle trafficking networks, and improve public safety. There is no doubt these technologies possess legitimate investigative value.



The concern has never been whether surveillance tools can be used for good.

History demonstrates they often can.

The concern is whether governments consistently resist expanding their use once the infrastructure exists.

Experience suggests otherwise.

Whether it was counterterrorism authorities following the attacks of September 11, expanding license plate databases, or the growing use of facial recognition, surveillance powers have often broadened beyond their original scope over time. Civil liberties organizations have repeatedly warned that technologies introduced for exceptional circumstances frequently become normalized for routine investigations.

That phenomenon has a name: mission creep.

The question Christians—and indeed all citizens—should be asking is not simply whether today's officials can be trusted. It is whether every future government, every future administration, and every future bureaucracy should inherit an infrastructure capable of reconstructing nearly every movement, association, and relationship of ordinary citizens.

Technology itself is morally neutral.

The same tools that locate kidnapped children could also be used to identify political dissidents. The same systems that help solve violent crimes could one day reveal where citizens worship, which rallies they attend, what organizations they support, or whom they regularly meet.

That is why safeguards matter before capabilities become routine.

For Christians, these developments also serve as a reminder that the technological foundations for unprecedented governmental oversight are no longer the stuff of science fiction. Scripture describes a future in which economic activity, identification, and governmental control become deeply intertwined on a global scale. SignalTrace illustrates how rapidly the technological infrastructure capable of comprehensive tracking is being assembled.

One invention rarely changes the world overnight.

Rather, history advances one seemingly reasonable innovation at a time.

A camera here.

A license plate reader there.

A facial recognition database.

A digital ID.

An AI analytics engine.

An electronic fingerprint.

Individually, each appears manageable. Collectively, they form something previous generations could scarcely have imagined—a society in which anonymity steadily disappears and nearly every movement leaves a searchable digital trail.

Perhaps that is why the title of Leonardo's latest system is so revealing.

The vehicle was never really the destination.

The destination was always the person.

And in a world filled with connected technology, every device is quietly becoming a tracking device.



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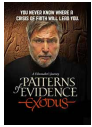
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